Notes about the Waverley Council Election Experience

In response to the abuse and accusations that I and other [redacted] volunteers experienced in the local council election on September 14, 2024, I documented people's experience in the weeks that followed to see what - and attempt to understand why - this occurred.

There were two disrupter groups: Better Councils and Citizens for Harmony. See below.

I interviewed some 25 volunteers and [redacted] candidates, largely from Waverley [redacted] but some from Woollahra and Randwick too.

In short, no-one had experienced hostility and aggression at the polling booths like it. Across the board from stalwart [redacted] to relatively recent volunteers, many were confounded and shell shocked. One volunteer who has worked on over 30 federal, state and local elections and was a pre-poll booth captain, said it was the worst aggression he had ever experienced.

"This was the worst abuse I've experienced in an election, by tenfold. It was the most ugly election I've been involved in for bad and aggressive behaviour."

A conservative estimate of the number of abusive incidents is 1000 in the Waverley Council electorate. This is based on volunteers typically saying that they had three comments per hour. This calculation is based on two volunteers per shift at pre-polling at Bondi Junction and Margaret Whitlam Centre (3x10x2=60. 60+60=120) for seven days (120x7 = 840) plus polling day with 60 volunteers across 10 booths.

At the same times, Waverley [redacted] had 100 corflutes taken down, often shortly after they were put up. Randwick estimates around 500 were torn down as it had the capacity to patrol early in the morning and put new corflutes back up whereas Waverley didn't have the manpower for this.

Waverley corflutes were defaced with stickers: 'corrupt', 'fraud' and 'racist'. Also, some were covered with October 7 Israeli hostage posters. The people putting stickers on [redacted] posters, captured by some CCTV cameras, put stickers on [redacted]'s corflute, one of the candidates. The corflute with a 'racist' sticker was then hoisted up high on a

light pole at an intersection where it remained for days because it was difficult to get down.

CCTV footage at Margaret Whitlam showed people wearing balaclavas removing the corflutes.

A Waverley [redacted] member paid for security on three booths overnight before the election to protect the corflutes that were put up on Friday night from being torn down. One booth, Clovelly Public School, that didn't have security had its corflutes taken down. Bondi Public School's [redacted] corflutes were all vandalised with [redacted]'s corflutes plastered with 'corrupt' stickers.

A gang of around 9 street kids appeared at the Bondi Junction mall in the early afternoon wanting to know "Where are the [redacted]?". A [redacted] volunteer thought they looked like trouble. Two were spaced out and staggering. He asked them where they were from but they kept repeating: "Where are the [redacted]?". One of the boys who appeared to be in his early teens told the [redacted] volunteer that he would have sex with him for money. Eventually they found the [redacted] volunteer. There was speculation that the kids had been paid to disrupt the [redacted].

An article about graffiti on Bondi Junction on September 10, 2024 tied the [redacted] to it.

[redacted]

The two disrupter groups

<u>Better Council Inc.</u>
Better Council Inc. (Better Council) was registered with the Electoral Commission by [redacted], after launching in May this year as a one-dollar company by director and owner, [redacted].
Another name at the bottom of the Better Council placards is [redacted] of [redacted], who is married to Israeli [redacted].

[redacted] staged the Cairo Café incident with a News Corporation journalist, [redacted] on February 11 this year. [redacted]

Citizens for Harmony

Citizens For Harmony is authorised by [redacted], a former lieutenant in the Maglan unit of the Israeli Special Forces. He has a business in Australia called [redacted].

Here are the patterns of what was said to the [redacted]:

Often the same comment was used by different people. The most common verbal abuse:
"You're antisemitic".
Other abuse to the [redacted] included:
"You're racists"
"You're fascists"
'You're terrorists"
"You're Hamas sympathisers and anti-Israel."
"I'd rather eat poison than vote for the [redacted]."
"You're disgusting."
"How can you stand there?"
"Nazis"
"How can you show your face?"
"I used to vote for the [redacted], but I don't vote for Hamas apologists."
Frequently people tore up [redacted] How to Vote handouts in front of the volunteers, in what one volunteer said was 'a rehearsed manoeuvre' saying "where do I put this rubbish?" Or hand it to the Better Councils person.
Some wanted to disrupt conversations that the [redacted] were having with voters by breaking into the conversation and saying: 'You're antisemitic.'
Rarely were any comments about the local council.

Here are some examples of some of the uglier confrontations:
One man said to a councillor: "You should be hung, drawn and quartered. Then put a bullet in you."
Some screamed in the faces of the [redacted].

At the St Joseph's pre-polling booth, a woman in her forties constantly called one [redacted] volunteer, who is 77, 'antisemitic', the [redacted] volunteer told me she replied, "Look, I'm Jewish, and therefore I'm not antisemitic. My parents escaped from Hungary in the Holocaust, and part of my family was murdered. Part of my family was shot. So yes, I have every sympathy for Israel and Jewish people, but not for what's going on at the moment."
The woman, in her 40s, grabbed the top of this volunteer's T-shirt and screamed that she should be ashamed of herself. "Then she stepped back, realizing her mistake."
One woman told a councillor:
"You shouldn't live here. You don't deserve to live here. This place is just for us.
He replied, "What do you mean? I've lived here for 50 years. How dare you say to me that because I'm not Jewish."
She responded, "This is our place. This is ours."
Another [redacted] woman at Margaret Whitlam recounted:
"There was one guy that walked up to me and was really close. He just slowed down right in front of me, turned towards me so that other people couldn't see. And he was punching his hand like the palm of his hand, like really low down and looking me in the eye. He was right in my personal space, yes, and he was, he had his hand low down, kind of like in front of his crutch or hips, and he was doing it so that it wasn't, you know, in view of everyone, and he just looked at me, looked at my me right in the face, like with this really angry look on his face, and he just punched his hand repeatedly, like he wanted to hit me. I mean, that's violence actually. That's actually an assault."

One woman said,
"Do you know how many of us there are?
16 million.
Do you know how many Muslims there are?
2 billion."

One [redacted] volunteer said the anger was palpable from some voters. "It was so constant and so fierce."

One volunteer who managed the Waverley Public School booth on election day, described how she felt scared. She felt nervous about a car bumper sticker and potential vandalism.

“This was vicious, and I actually felt scared. I got to the point where I covered my shirt up when I left the booth,”

“And then later that morning, a guy came up, stood right in my personal space, and he just looked to me and said: “Where do you get the nerve? And he was just like, yelling at me. At first, I tried not to say anything. He said, answer me. Where do you get the nerve? Then he said, answer me. And I said, I don't feel like you're interested in anything I want to say to you. That was my reaction. And then he said, I'm very interested in you've got in what you've got to say. And I just said, I don't think so. And then he said, hey, you tell me. How do you have the nerve to stand here? You're antisemitic and you're not even ashamed of it. And I said, I'm sorry you feel that way, and he was just going, this is disgusting. And at that point, and he was shaking his fist he was furious. He was right in my face. At that point, the guy from [redacted], [redacted], just said, please move away. You're being aggressive and abusive, and I don't have to put up with it. I said, Get away from me. And he moved on. And then he went to [redacted]. I don't know what he said to her.”

She said the [redacted] didn’t do anything and one of the Residents First was laughing, she found it amusing.

A 40-year-old [redacted] volunteer at Cooper Park who gave another [redacted] a break from the polling booth was repeatedly abused by voters, so much so that a Residents First supporter who knew the original woman had to step in.

“She said oh my god, she's had the most dreadful time. She's been really abused. And I went up to her, and she's a really lovely lady, and I just looked at her, and I could see she just had it. And I said, I'm so sorry that's happened to you. And she just burst into tears. And you know, I gave her a big hug, and she said, Oh, I'm alright. I said, Oh, well, I'm bad. It was me that collapsed, and she'd just been abused by Zionists, and it had absolutely psyched her, and it happened to me periodically through the day. It always does there, and it's nasty you just can't reason with them, as you well know there is no way of communicating with them. In fact, my standard line I've learned is that we stand for peace and non-violence, which usually makes them piss off.”

She was reduced to tears and had to leave.

This also happened to me at Bondi Junction, and I had a RF supporter who told a woman screaming in my face to leave me alone. I was also shoved by a Better Councils woman.

In summary here is what shocked some of the [redacted] people about the two disrupter groups, Better Councils and Citizens for Harmony:

As one experienced [redacted] volunteer in Woollahra said that both groups brought about real change in polling booth behaviour. “That disruption from the orange people (Better Councils) was a totally negative influence. They weren't saying anything positive and have no policy. They have nothing to offer that could be discussed, that could be debated. They just wanted to disrupt, and they did a good job. These people were just looking for avenues to create unrest,”

“It's about destabilisation. They don't have anything to put in its place, but they just want to fracture society, destabilize it and then hope they'll see opportunities for their benefit down the line.”

“Better Councils created a hostile environment at the polling booths. They told impressionable voters lies about the [redacted].”

“It affects the ability to hand out and speak to the punters in their own space freely. You know, that's what we're in danger of losing, and we need to think about what we can do to make sure we don't lose that.”

One [redacted] councillor said she was surprised by the diversity of the people involved, from older individuals to young children. She heard of a group of primary school children handing out Better Council’s leaflets. Another [redacted] volunteer was approached by a schoolboy in his school uniform that she estimated to be around 15 asking for a brochure. When he took it, he said: “I want to read what racist policies the [redacted] have.”

Another [redacted] person encountered kids handing out Vote the [redacted] last at Bondi Junction without any parental supervision.

Most of the hostile voters wouldn’t listen any responses from the [redacted].

Other [redacted] said:

“And I heard him saying to a voter, the [redacted] couldn't care less if every Jew in Israel was eradicated. And I yelled out, that's not true. And then the guy just turned around and I said, What are you talking about?”

“And then it got even more confusing when those people (Citizens for Harmony) with little white sheets were handing that out with the put the [redacted] last people. They kind of boxed people in and stood together, and they kind of trapped you, or they trapped the voters.”

Implications

This was an effective external influence on the local government elections, resulting in the election of more [redacted] members in Waverley, Woollahra and Randwick. If these attempts to influence voters were indeed an act of foreign interference, there remains a risk of similar attempts during future state and territory election campaigns and this year’s federal election. Israel stands to benefit from a change in government and would prefer a [redacted] government in Australia because it has demonstrated support for Israel’s military operations in the Middle East.
This tactic of intimidation, if unchecked, may evolve in a more aggressive way.

The abuse and the two disrupter groups, Better Councils and Citizens for Harmony had the effect of:

Diminishing the effectiveness of the [redacted]

Voters were confused by the word [redacted] used by both groups and the [redacted] symbols used by both groups. Some voters thought that they were the [redacted].
Some of the Better Councils were large, muscled men who shouted and stood on the chalk line. Their presence was overwhelming, and they bailed up voters. They told voters things like the garbage was a problem because of the [redacted] and had laminated photos of garbage.

Some [redacted] decided to stand a distance away from Better Council and CFH and this meant that they weren’t in the best position to hand out how to vote brochures.

Some volunteers said they were frustrated at being smeared by false allegations.

In a few cases some volunteers took off their [redacted] t-shirts and badges and were more selective about who they handed the brochures to.

The Better Council people sometimes outnumbered the [redacted] at pre-poll booths such as Bondi Junction and St Josephs at Woollahra. They formed a barrier so that the [redacted] couldn't get to voters.

Some [redacted] said nothing seemed to work to quell the accusations, except to ignore them. If volunteers said that they weren't antisemitic, they were called liars.

Other [redacted] said they stood for peace, and it had an effect.

Some [redacted] wondered what State and Federal [redacted] were doing to tear down the lies and communicate that the [redacted] are not antisemitic.